

can deposit regular amounts or lump sums according to what works best for you. If things get a little complex, it's also worth speaking to a financial advisor about setting things up in the right way.

It's also worth noting that, because of compounding – where the returns that you make on your pension investments are reinvested to make further returns (i.e. more money becomes even more money) – it's a brilliant idea to contribute to your pension from as early in your career as possible. Even a small amount, invested regularly from an early age and allowed to grow, will make a huge difference over the course of a few decades. However, if retirement seems to be approaching quicker than you'd like, and you're worried about your pension, it really is never too late to start.

Something that we really must cover, when it comes to pensions, is the gargantuan gender pension gap that exists. The average gap is 38%, rising to 57% in some areas of the UK,³ and the gap is starker still for Black women and single mothers, among other under-pensioned groups.⁴ People who fall into multiple under-pensioned categories may have a pension pot that is a mere fraction of the UK average, and an even smaller fraction of the average pension for men. There are a huge number of systemic failures that allow this to happen, from the gender and race pay gaps to the way that employer contributions and auto-enrolment are set up, but, if you're a woman, it's important to take action as early as possible to minimize this gap for your own future, if you possibly can. To